

SI-MI: Social Identity Matters in Mentoring

Session 4: Racialized Experiences in STEM

Guiding question: How can mentors understand and respond to racialized experiences in STEM while recognizing the limits of individual mentoring within systemic inequities?

Overview: This session examines how racism and other forms of marginalization shape experiences in STEM, especially for Black, Indigenous, and other people of color. Participants will explore these experiences as systemic rather than purely interpersonal issues and will consider what culturally aware mentoring can and cannot do within larger structures of inequity.

Objectives:

- Increase understanding of racialized experiences and barriers in STEM.
- Distinguish between systemic change and individual mentoring action.
- Reflect on the role of culturally aware mentoring within broader institutional inequities.

Before the Session: Complete the assigned article, podcast, and reflection before the session. Be prepared to think critically about the limits of mentoring, the value of culturally aware practice, and the difference between individual support and systemic change.

- **Read:** Nature Geoscience - [Scientists from Historically Excluded Groups Face a Hostile Obstacle Course](#)
- **Listen:** The Pitt Pulse Podcast - [Introduction to Racism in STEM with Dr. Ebony McGee](#) (31 min)
- **Reflect:**
 - Did the materials bring up any racialized experiences you have witnessed or lived? If so, how did this experience feel?
 - In the podcast, Dr. McGee states that mentoring programs “cannot dismantle 400 years of structural racism in society.” With that in mind, consider the following questions:
 - Is the work we are doing in this mentor training transformative?
 - If not, what purpose does it serve? What issues doesn't it solve?
 - What does being a culturally aware mentor do for mentees in your sphere of influence?

What to Expect in the Live Session: The live session will include guided reflection, group discussion, and opportunities to process emotional and practical responses to racialized experiences in academia. Participants should expect a thoughtful conversation that links structural realities to mentoring practice.

Takeaways:

- Racialized experiences in STEM are shaped by systemic inequities, not just individual interactions.
- Mentors play an important supportive role but cannot replace structural change.
- Acknowledging racism directly is more supportive than minimizing or avoiding it.